

Om Truths

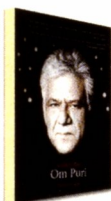
A prodigious actor's rise from obscurity makes compelling reading, despite the author

By Kaveree Bamzai

Journalism's loss is Om Puri's gain. And thank God for it. Writing is not former journalist Nandita C. Puri's strong suit which explains why she almost mangles an all-access biography of one of the most gifted actors of our time. An actor whose prodigious acting talent appears to have been matched by his uncanny ability to date two women at the same time, claw his way out of a poverty-stricken childhood into two of India's most elite institutions, NSD and FTII, and then craft an international movie career that has made him the West's favourite onscreen Pakistani.

And it is when Puri speaks, whether on getting the accent right to play a Pakistani in *East in East*, or facing off as Zia-ul-Haq against the affable Tom Hanks, that the book is at its best. Despite the author's best efforts to drown out Puri's rich baritone, the actor emerges as flawed, but also fun. Here he is on how Seema Sawhni, Ismat Chughtai's charming daughter, took him under her wing and introduced him to Mumbai's high society. There he is on how his father would routinely embarrass him among friends, once even crossing the Prithvi Theatre stage unmindful of Naseeruddin Shah and Benjamin Gilani performing *Waiting for Godot*. And here he is again on how he prepared for his role in Roland Joffe's *City of Joy*, by pulling the rickshaw barefoot all over Kolkata, and learning to weave in a little village near Pochampalli for Shyam Benegal's *Susman*.

The book recalls the flowering of middle cinema, a time when pioneers like producer Manmohan Shetty, director Benegal, and actors Shah and Smita Patil were at the top of their game. When actors shared girlfriends, fought good-naturedly for the same roles, when salaries could buy only a fridge and black and white tv, when best actor awards at Karlovy Vary mattered, and when a maestro like Satyajit Ray would come to the railway station to pick up his star actor. But perhaps the most entertaining for readers will be the account of his love life, from his deflowering at 14 to making a former girlfriend endure two abortions to sleeping with his cook to cheating on his first wife. But it should all firmly be clubbed in a section called too much information. What makes it particularly exciting is that the author is his wife. Despite the diversions, the actor's life, sometimes up, often down, full of what-may-have-beens and what-must-be-dones, is the secret gem you unearth in a book that could have been produced better. Ignore the lethargic editing, the awkwardly inserted testimonials from the actor's colleagues and the much-publicised Maidgate, and enjoy a life well lived. ■



UNLIKELY HERO:
OM PURI
by NANDITA C. PURI
Lotus/Roli
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Pages: 208

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Sidney Sheldon and Tilly Bagshaw, HarperCollins
4. The Winner Stands Alone
Paulo Coelho, HarperCollins
5. The 3 Mistakes of My Life
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa

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